

Sweet Dreams: The Power of Sleep

We spend nearly a third of our lives doing it, but what is really happening?

Sleep is our body's chance to rest, an opportunity for our brain to go into 'low energy' mode and clean up, a time to 'bank' the day's memories for another time.

Sleep is divided into two main states: non-REM and REM.

What Are Dreams?

No-one really knows! Some believe that dreams are your brain's way of expressing your subconscious. Sigmund Freud, an influential psychoanalyst in Europe in the 19th and 20th centuries, believed that interpreting people's dreams could help to relieve their neuroses.

Are You Getting Enough? Compare Your Sleep Habits with these Daily Targets:

- Newborn - 19 hours a day
- Primary school pupil - 11 hours
- Teenager - 10 hours
- Adult - 8 hours

Is Sleep Important?

It may seem tedious turning in for bed when you want to stay up, but anyone who has seen the sunrise without sleeping first will attest that it is pretty crucial! The symptoms hit hard: grumpiness, irritability, lack of concentration, confusion and disorganisation. For drivers, it can be life threatening.

REM (rapid eye movement)	Non-REM
Short, about 10 minutes	Long, about 90 minutes
Muscles paralysed	Muscles work and we move around
Eyes move around quickly	Body temperature falls
Dream	Heart rate slows



Sleep Disorders

Some people's sleep is far from rejuvenating and can leave people feeling even worse. Sleep apnoea is a condition where the sufferer becomes oxygen-deprived in their sleep and so their brain disturbs them to enable them to start breathing but not enough to fully wake up and realise. A big clue is loud snoring but often the only noticeable difference is exhaustion.



Sleepwalking

A common TV trope is the comedic sleepwalker: somebody performing an everyday function in their sleep, often with hilarious consequences. However, this can make life truly difficult. People can make a cup of tea, get dressed or even climb out of their window, all while asleep. Most frightening of all, the sleepwalker will have no recollection of their nocturnal actions.

Some scientists believe it is caused by our body 'forgetting' to paralyse our muscles during REM, so dreams begin to be acted out.

Night Terrors

Another very distressing disorder are night terrors: the evil twin of nightmares. The sufferer will wake up to find themselves in a terrifying situation but unable to make a move or make a sound. They are in an REM sleep cycle but their body has woken them up and so their dream appears to be reality.

Narcolepsy

Ever fallen asleep in class? For narcoleptics this is exactly what they face: falling asleep whenever and wherever and often with very little warning. Sometimes it is triggered by a particular emotional reaction, such as laughing, and is often accompanied by muscle weakness so the sufferer may collapse at the same time.

The Key to a Good Night's Sleep

There is nothing like waking up, on the right side of bed, feeling refreshed and ready to take on the day. But how can this be achieved?



Sleep well!

Top Five Suggestions From Sleep Specialists:

1. Go to bed at the same time every night.
2. Wind down by having a warm bath or reading a book.
3. Avoid blue light like that emitted from screens.
4. Avoid stimulants like caffeine and chocolate.
5. Keep your room quiet, dark, tidy and between 18 - 24°C.